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Getting to Know ... Mike Lane

[Tuesday, June 26, 2007](#)

A native of Long Island , N.Y., Mike Lane owns a communications and political strategy consulting firm. He moved to Alexandria in January 2006 after living in Arlington for almost 30 years. Elected to the Arlington County Board in 1999, Lane is the only nominated Republican elected to any public office in Arlington in the past 38 years. After unpacking in Alexandria, he immediately joined the Alexandria Republican City Committee and volunteered to manage then School Board Member Ken Foran's campaign for City Council.

Why are you a Republican?

Government plays an important role in our lives, but it should be limited. Individual responsibility should play a more prominent role. My perception is Democrats look to the government as the first solution to any situation, where I feel more comfortable with the Republican view that government ought to be the solution of last resort.

What does it mean to be a Republican in Alexandria?

When you live in the shadow of the Capitol dome, it is difficult to persuade voters that Alexandria Republicans are not the Republicans of Texas or Florida or even Richmond. Alexandria Republicans are moderate, practical, results-oriented citizens who seek a reasonable balance and accountability in government.

What do you think are the most pressing concerns now facing the city government?

The lack of diversity of thought in city government is a real problem. Monopolies are rarely consumer friendly, and monopoly government is never good for anyone. City Council is often unresponsive to neighborhoods and individual citizens because they don't have to be. An independent, alternative voice in Alexandria government that gives voice to the unheard would be a real improvement.

How important is the current special election?

Critical. As the winner of a special election in Arlington in 1999, I know first-hand the importance of a balanced approach to government, and how necessary diversity of thought is to successful government. My friend Bill Cleveland is an independent, thoughtful and experienced voice whose return to City Council would greatly benefit Alexandria. Conversely, maintaining monopoly party government where diverse opinions are discouraged is not helpful.

What are your hobbies?

Winery hopping at Virginia vineyards is a recurring pastime. And we collect Robert Portner memorabilia. (Portner was one of Alexandria's most prominent merchants and a Republican City Councilman in the mid-1800s). I am also an avid photographer.

What is the best book you have read in the last year?

I confess to being a Nelson DeMille addict. "Wild Fire" features the continuing role of likeable protagonist John Corey.

What is your favorite movie and why?

Almost any classic filmed in black and white. I never miss a chance to watch "Casablanca" when it is on.

What is your favorite local restaurant?

Vaso's Kitchen just got a permit for outdoor dining which will be a real asset. I try never to miss a half-price chiliburger on Monday night at Hard Times Café, but they still haven't heeded my request to restore Lone Star Beer to the menu. Union Street and Finn and Porter have great happy hours. Sunday jazz-brunch at 100 King. Late night's at the Morrison House piano bar. Did I mention Clyde's?

What are your goals?

I would like to make an active contribution to the quality of life in Alexandria. I have just been invited to join the Board of the Lee-Fendell House, and I look forward to protecting and promoting our city's historical heritage. I will soon ask the city council for an appointment to a citizen's commission and beyond that, I will assess how best to make additional contributions at the appropriate time.

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